

How to Influence People: 4 Skills for Influencing Others

Influencing others is essential, but it's more than just giving commands. See how leaders who inspire, persuade, and encourage can create a common goal and achieve results.

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To be truly effective — in good times and in times of great challenge — leaders must know how to influence people. By definition, influence is the ability to affect the behavior of others in a particular direction, leveraging key tactics that involve, connect, and inspire them.

That's why we've identified "influencing others" as one of the [4 core leadership skills needed in every role](#). (Communicating, learning agility, and self-awareness are the other 3.)

Without the expertise and ability to influence others, the truly important things in work and in life can't be achieved.

But effective leaders don't just command; they inspire, persuade, and encourage. Leaders tap the knowledge and skills of a group, point individuals toward a common goal and consensus, and draw out a commitment to achieve results.

Influencing People Varies by Role



Early in your career, or in individual contributor roles, influence is about working effectively with people over whom you have no authority. It requires the ability to present logical and compelling arguments and engage in give-and-take.

When leading from the middle, you'll want to focus particularly on developing the 4 key skills needed to influence others, which we expand on below.

In senior-level or executive roles, influencing others is more about steering long-range objectives, inspiring and motivating others, and [communicating the vision](#).

But wherever you are in an organization, chances are you'll want to master tactics to influence people, as influence is one of the 4 core leadership skills needed in every role.

"Without the capacity to influence others, your ability to make what you envision a reality remains elusive because, after all, no one can do it alone," notes George Hallenbeck, a lead contributor to our [Lead 4 Success®](#) program, which helps leaders develop these 4 key essentials of leadership.

Influencing Others: 4 Key Skills

4 Influencing Skills



The best leaders have these 4 key influencing skills:

- **Organizational Intelligence:** They understand how to get things done and embrace the reality of working within organizational politics to move teams and important initiatives forward.
- **Team Promotion:** Leaders cut through the noise to authentically and credibly promote themselves — while also promoting what's good for the entire organization.
- **Trust-Building:** Because leadership often involves guiding people through risk and change, trust is essential.
- **Leveraging Networks:** No leader is an island. They are empowered by their connections with others.

Here's a look at each of these influencing skills in a little more detail, and how you and your team can use them to influence others.

1. Practice “Organizational Intelligence.”

All organizations have 2 sides: the formal structure pictured on the org chart and the informal structure, which more often represents how things really get done. Politically savvy leaders understand both.

Political savvy is both a mindset and a skillset. Savvy leaders view politics as a neutral and necessary part of organizational life that can be used constructively and ethically to advance organizational aims.

For a leader, [political skills](#) in action look like:

- Networking to build social capital, including mingling strategically.
- Thinking before responding, considering context and goals before deciding when and how to express their point of view.
- Paying close attention to nonverbal cues, practicing active listening, considering how others might feel, and finding ways to appeal to the common good.
- Leaving people with a good impression, without coming across as “trying too hard.”

2. Promote Yourself, Promote Your Team.

Self-promotion is often seen as bragging or selfishness. But leaders who know how to influence people understand that by promoting themselves authentically and for the right reasons, they can cut through the information that bombards us all each day.

In the hands of an astute leader, [authentic self-promotion](#) isn't just a tool to advance one's own career. It can provide visibility and opportunities for their direct reports, generate team and organizational pride, and make capabilities and ideas more visible across the organization — ultimately enhancing collaboration and consensus.

Two self-promotion strategies stand out.

First, **leaders who are good at influencing others find ways to gather an audience.** They may ask more people to be part of a team, initiative, or problem-solving process.

Second, **they find ways to “put on a show” and step into the spotlight** at selected events and meetings, sometimes creating their own events.

3. Build & Maintain a Foundation of Trust.

Building and maintaining [leadership trust](#) is essential. Without trust, leaders may be able to force people to comply, but they'll never tap the full commitment, capabilities, and creativity the group can offer. Leveraging these assets is invaluable when tackling tough challenges or making strategic change, so trust is vital.

People look for leaders who can appreciate their vulnerability and inspire them, understand them, support them, and guide them through looming chaos. This requires the leader to demonstrate a broad range of expertise and behaviors, some of which might seem contradictory but, when used in an appropriate and timely manner, create conditions that foster trust.

Trust involves a careful balance between pushing people into areas where they're uncomfortable while also listening carefully to their concerns and feedback. Among the many “balancing acts” they must work to maintain, trustworthy leaders negotiate between toughness and empathy as individuals struggle with transition, as well as urgency with patience as change proceeds.

4. Leverage Networks.

Finally, leaders that know how to influence people recognize and cultivate the power of networks. Organizations are increasingly dynamic; they morph in size and shape over time. Influential leaders have [a network perspective](#) and recognize that their personal networks must also be dynamic and growing. They're also strategic about choosing how and when to tap into this network.



When Influencing Others, Remember Context Matters

Across all 4 of these influencing skills — political savvy, self-promotion, building trust, and networking — context is important.

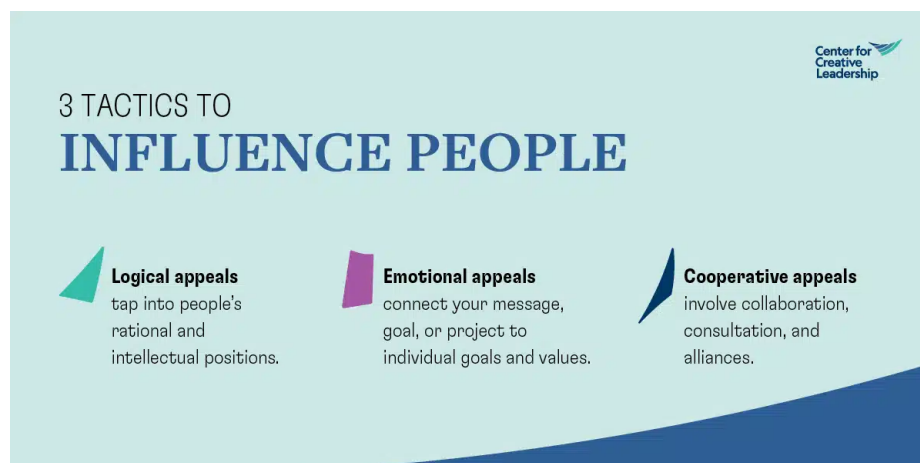
The goal is to influence others, *not* manipulate them.

Effective, ethical leaders use different approaches in different situations, choosing carefully when and how to influence people using influencing tactics that appeal to the head, heart, or hands. For example, a leader may use rational persuasion techniques when there's factual evidence to present. On the other hand, they may opt to use inspirational appeals or consultation methods to generate buy-in when discussing a new project or proposal with their team.

3 Tactics for Influencing Others

We've found that influencing tactics fall into 3 categories: logical, emotional, or cooperative appeals. In other words, using the head, heart, or hands to influence people:

- **Logical Appeals (Head):** Tap into people's rational and intellectual positions. You present an argument for the best choice of action based on organizational benefits, personal benefits, or both, to appeal to people's minds.
- **Emotional Appeals (Heart):** Connect your message, goal, or project to individual goals and values. An idea that promotes a person's feelings of wellbeing, service, or [sense of belonging](#) tugs at the heartstrings and has a good chance of gaining support.
- **Cooperative Appeals (Hands):** Involve collaboration, consultation, and alliances. Working together to accomplish a mutually important goal extends a hand to others in the organization and is an extremely effective way to influence people. Leaders who effectively use these tactics to influence people can achieve their goals and objectives more successfully than leaders who lack that ability, regardless of where they sit in an organization.



Leaders need to understand why they're doing something — and be clear about their own values, goals, and point of view when applying their influence skills and planning their approach.

That way, influencing others comes from a place of authenticity and has the greatest impact.

Unsure where to start? Think about a situation in the near future when you will need to influence someone, and reflect on the following questions to form a plan:

- *Who am I attempting to influence?*
- *What is the situation? How much support do I need?*
- *Why do I need this person's support of my idea?*
- *What tactics can I use, and how can I establish rapport?*
- *What responses do I anticipate?*
- *What mutual points of agreement can I use?*
- *How can I end on a positive note, no matter what the outcome is?*

How to Recognize When You're Being Influenced

When you're a leader who is used to being the influencer, it can be challenging to identify when the tables have been turned. If fellow teammates or executives are trying to persuade you, it's important to recognize when and how you're being influenced.

To start, gain some self-awareness about your own biases and personal point of view. Determine your current strengths and development needs, and understand that you will typically act out of your strengths.

Ask yourself, *"What will it take for me to be more aware and balance my typical approach to be more effective with others?"*

The better you understand yourself, the better you'll be at understanding others. If you do find yourself being influenced, consider leveraging the consultation tactic in response to offer up your thoughts, desires, and suggestions for discussion. This type of collaboration will be an especially helpful technique if you disagree and need to negotiate a path forward. You may discover that the time you've spent thinking about the most effective way to influence others will come in very handy.

Based on Research by



George Hallenbeck, PhD

Portfolio Manager, Custom Solutions

George manages our portfolio of custom solutions. He's a recognized expert in the area of learning agility and has been engaged in research, product development, and client activities related to the topic for over 15 years. He has authored or co-authored 8 books, including [Lead 4 Success: Learn the Essentials of True Leadership](#), which shaped the development of our [Lead 4 Success leadership fundamentals course](#).



At the Center for Creative Leadership, our drive to create a ripple effect of positive change underpins everything we do. For 50+ years, we've pioneered leadership development solutions for leaders at every level, from community leaders to CEOs. Consistently ranked among the top global providers of executive education, our research-based programs and solutions inspire individuals at every level in organizations across the world — including 2/3 of the Fortune 1000 — to ignite remarkable transformations.

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Essential Communication Skills for Leaders

When done well, leadership communication inspires trust and positive change, and drives better outcomes for individuals, teams, and organizations.

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What's Communication in Leadership & Why Is It Important?

Good communication is a fundamental leadership skill and a [key characteristic of a good leader](#). Leaders must be skilled at communicating with others in countless settings and relationships — with individuals and at the organizational level, in communities and groups, and sometimes even on a global scale — in order to achieve results through others.

What Is Leadership Communication?

Leadership communication is how leaders inform and inspire others, and it encompasses verbal, nonverbal, and written messages. From giving instructions and feedback to direct reports, to sharing the vision with employees, to mediating conflict with teams, to providing updates to stakeholders — effective communication in leadership is critical.



Why Is Communication Important for Leaders?

At CCL, we see communication as one of the [“fundamental 4” core leadership skills](#) — those timeless skills needed by leaders in any organization, regardless of role, industry, or location.

Leaders must be able to think with clarity, express ideas, and share information with a multitude of audiences. They must also handle the rapid flows of information within the organization and among colleagues, customers, partners, vendors, and others.

Effective leadership communication allows managers to deepen connections, build trust, and drive creativity and innovation through their daily interactions with others. It also helps during change or disruption, as communication is one of 3 critical competencies that our research has found are essential for [successful change leadership](#).

The Connection Between Communication, Conversations & Culture

In organizations, conversations are the foundation upon which the majority of communication happens, as people communicate every day through the formal and informal discussions they have with colleagues and leaders. And the more effective these conversations are, the stronger their organizations become — because [better conversations drive better culture](#).

Core Traits of Successful Leadership Communication



Authenticity

Be honest and sincere. Find your own voice; avoid using corporate-speak or sounding like someone you're not. Let who you are, where you come from, and what you value come through in your communication. People want, respect, and will follow [authentic leadership](#). Forget about eloquence — worry about being real. Don't disguise who you are. People will never willingly follow someone they feel is inauthentic.

Accessibility

Visibility is a form of communication. If you want to communicate well, be accessible. Emails and official missives aren't enough. Be present, visible, and available. Getting "out there" — consistently and predictably — lets others know what kind of leader you are. People need to see and feel who you are to feel connected to the work you want them to do. Find ways to interact with all of your stakeholder groups, even (and especially) if [communicating in a crisis](#).

Clarity & Confidence

Being clear and confident when communicating with your team helps avoid ambiguity, misinterpretation, and confusion. Speak in specifics, use nonverbal communication to augment your words, and speak not just with facts but also with feelings and values. Being able to speak clearly and confidently builds trust and commitment with your team.

Empathy & Respect

Empathy is critical for leadership success, and that extends to communication. Employees want empathy from their leaders and appreciate compassionate leadership. Acknowledge their feelings and pain points when you speak to them, and that will help them feel valued and heard, creating a strong culture of psychological safety.

Trust

Trust isn't something you can mandate — it grows from consistently demonstrating your commitment to better communication with those you work with. By modeling the values you hope to foster in your team and in your organization, you can build trust. And by building trust, you also encourage those around you to communicate more authentically, contributing to a culture of [psychological safety at work](#). When people feel safe with their team and organization, they're more open to sharing ideas and taking risks, which can lead to more creativity and more innovation.

15 Tips for Effective Leadership Communication

1. Communicate relentlessly.

Get vocal and get involved. Communicate information, thoughts, and ideas clearly — and frequently — in different media. Keep processes open and transparent, and find ways to help smooth the path of communication for your team, employees, or organization. Shed all traces of detachment and arrogance, and take the time to talk to your people.

2. Set clear expectations.

Set the tone. In every relationship, our behavior is guided by a set of rules or social norms — and in a professional setting, these norms tend to go unspoken. Be intentional about [establishing team norms](#) at your organization, whether you're leading a group discussion, mediating a conflict between employees, sending an email to your colleagues, or having a one-on-one conversation with a direct report.

3. Simplify and be direct.

Say what you mean. Be direct. Don't hide behind complexity or pile on a ton of information. Direct, clear communication can be the most important type of communication. This is even more important when [communicating in a virtual setting](#).

4. Illustrate through stories.



Use stories to bring your ideas to life. When you tell a good story, you help clarify a vision, goal, or objective. Telling good stories creates trust, captures hearts and minds, and serves as a memorable reminder of the message. This is key when [communicating the vision](#). Plus, people find it easier to repeat a story or refer to an image or quote than to talk about a mission statement, strategy document, or project plan. Your ability to create and communicate a compelling, authentic, and bold story will also help you [bolster your leadership brand](#).

5. Be prepared.

Do your homework. Poor communication in the past might mean your audience resists what you have to say today. So start familiarizing yourself with the context around an issue, and any alternative viewpoints and perspectives about it, so you're ready to handle any concerns or objections *before* you initiate communication. If you're met with resistance or presented with a different position, solid preparation will make addressing and overcoming objections much easier and communicate your ideas more effectively.

6. Know your audience.

Communication isn't just about what you say — it's also about who is listening. Different stakeholders may have different concerns. The way you approach [influencing others](#) will vary from one group to the next, depending on their needs. Tailor your influencing strategy for the particular person and consider their personality, goals, and objectives, as well as their roles and responsibilities. For example, someone who is highly rational may be more easily swayed by a logical appeal than an emotional one.

7. Reinforce intent with body language.

Don't rely just on words. Showing positive body language like eye contact, nodding your head, and other relaxed nonverbal communication can inspire team members and make them feel more comfortable communicating with you. A simple head nod or smile can go a long way to show you're paying attention and that you care, and little gestures like this can add up, slowly helping you to build rapport and collaboration and transform your organizational culture, too.

8. Read the room.

Good leadership communication means being flexible. Watch your audience closely for nonverbal signs of engagement or disengagement, confusion or understanding, etc. and adjust your message and style accordingly. You can do this quite literally during in-person meetings, but you can also “read the room” in virtual settings by looking closely at others' faces on the screen and by explicitly soliciting feedback.

If people are understanding your communication and aligned with your message, you may get lots of eye contact, see nodding heads, observe audience members leaning forward or demonstrating other body language that suggests alignment with your message. If you see listeners leaning back, with arms crossed, and bored or confused expressions on their faces, then you may need to adjust your message or delivery style.

It's helpful to pause occasionally to let people ask questions and check for understanding, giving your listeners a chance to respond or seek clarification, etc. Stay flexible so you can continually notice how your communications are landing with your audience, and do ongoing adjustments based on the signals they send.

9. Ask good questions.

Leaders ask powerful questions. Ask powerful questions that open the door to learning what others really think and feel. The [best leadership questions](#) get right to the heart of things, cut through complicated situations, and identify levers that will really make a difference. Asking non-directive inquiries can also unlock insights — especially key in [coaching people](#), such as direct reports.

10. Listen and encourage input.

Good leaders listen more than they speak. Leadership communication isn't just about the messages you send, but also the messages you receive. The most effective communicators are also good listeners with strong [active listening skills](#). When you listen well, you gain a clear understanding of another's perspective and knowledge. So seek out, and then listen to, individuals from all levels of the organization — from the key stakeholders who have a lot of opinions you need to consider, to the new employees who may be reluctant to voice concerns. Allow people to air their concerns. Let team members know their input is valuable, so people feel comfortable speaking up. Pay close, respectful attention to what's said — *and* what's left unsaid. It will show those you lead that you care about both them *and* the organization.

Also, be okay with silence. Encourage others to offer their ideas and solutions before sharing yours. Do 80% of the listening and 20% of the talking. Demonstrate an interest in — and respect for — your colleagues, as this builds trust and makes the emotional connection that's so important for effective leadership.

11. Take feedback seriously.

Feedback is a gift. Asking for candid feedback from your team or employees can foster a positive stream of communication, and it helps build trust overall. This tactic can also make your team feel more respected, giving them a chance to have their voices heard. If you take their feedback seriously, you will grow as a leader and enhance your skillset. However, if you ask for and then *don't* incorporate their feedback, the opposite is true — it could lead to a loss of trust and alignment. In fact, [our research has found](#) that following through with action is *critical* for leaders to convey they really were listening, as it shows that they truly heard and understood the other person's concerns.

12. Affirm with actions.

Leaders don't just talk — they act. Again, if people hear one thing from you but see another, your credibility is damaged. If employees speak up and you seem to be listening, but then do nothing based on what you learned, they won't feel heard. People need to trust you. Your behavior and actions communicate a world of information — so focus on following up where appropriate and be clear on the messages you are sending with your actions.

13. Initiate the tough, but needed, conversations.

Don't shy away from conflict. [Holding difficult conversations](#), whether with a customer or direct report, are an inevitable part of any workplace. It's tempting to ignore conflicts, but effective leaders must be able to address concerns as they arise. Be sure to approach any difficult conversation from a neutral perspective and explore both sides before coming to a conclusion. Work to problem-solve by inventing options that meet each side's important concerns, and do your best to [resolve conflicts](#) through open communication.

14. Involve others before developing a plan of action.

Leadership doesn't stop when the communication ends. Take whatever you've learned in the exchange, synthesize it, and present your plan to the appropriate stakeholders. Generating buy-in and making sure that everyone is on the same page before executing on strategy will be key to achieving organizational goals.

15. Remember your reputation.

Good communicators never compromise their reputations. At times, you may feel you are walking a fine line between being too aggressive and being too relaxed, and as a leader, you need to make sure you find and balance and avoid leaning too heavily in one direction.



To navigate these challenges and bolster your [leadership image](#), consider asking yourself thought-provoking questions like, “*When do I stay out of an issue, and when do I get involved?*” or “*How do I respond when errors are identified?*” Make a list of communication concerns you have, and ask a colleague to describe the behaviors they would consider too aggressive or too relaxed — their responses will help gauge how to move forward.

How Poor Leadership Communication Can Cost Your Organization

Workplace communication is a moving target. Leaders must continue to find new ways to make their communications more effective, purposeful, and trustworthy. But, what if communication becomes stagnant, unorganized, and messy?

Leaders may unintentionally derail their own efforts to enhance their communication. They may not communicate enough because of a fear of oversharing, they may think out loud at the wrong moment, or they may have been too honest with a colleague.

These challenges typically arise in high-stress situations, when expectations or deadlines aren’t met, when an opportunity is lost, or when innovation is lacking. It can be frustrating, but it’s worth putting in the extra effort to tackle these conflicts head-on with candid conversations and productive debate, because when a conflict is mismanaged, costs will continue to mount — whether they result in tangible out-of-pocket costs like turnover, or intangible costs like poor morale, decision-making, or broken trust. Learn more about the impact of poor leadership communication in such situations and [the costs of conflict incompetence](#).

How to Evaluate Your Leadership Communication Skills

Strong communication is one of the quickest ways leaders can build trust. Here are some actions that you can take while communicating. As you’re reading them, rate yourself on a scale of 1 to 5 — with a 1 signifying it’s an area that you need to work on, and 5 meaning that you have excelled:

- Avoid mixed messages: ensure that your words and actions are consistent.
- Act in ways that support the values of your organization.
- Go directly to the relevant individual to discuss the situation if having difficulty with another coworker or team member.
- Serve as a sounding board on sensitive issues for others.
- Share your opinions and perspectives, even when they’re different from the majority view.
- Avoid being a “yes” person.
- Keep your focus on the big picture and the shared goals of the organization.
- Accept accountability for your actions and the results of those actions.
- Promote respectful dialogue and productive debate.

Now that you’ve assessed your skills, how high is your score? How well did you do? If you identified any areas that need improvement, begin today by marking the one that you will start with immediately to improve your skills in leadership communication.

Based on Research by



Maggie Sass, PhD

Former Global Portfolio Manager & Faculty

Maggie is an experienced consultant, solutions designer, researcher, and facilitator with expertise in leadership, executive coaching, assessment, authentic communication, and evaluation. She's coached and trained leaders around the world, and her research has focused on the unique challenges of first-time leaders as well as technology and ethics in coaching and leadership.



Andre Keil, MA, PCC

Former Coaching Director, Facilitator & Executive Coach

Andre led our coaches and on-call faculty, and he managed our coaching portfolio with focus on executive coaching, team coaching, coaching skills and certificate programs, and large-scale coaching culture engagements. He has also served on the Board of Directors for Coach Training for the International Coaching Federation (ICF).



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Youssef Halabi

Environmental Specialist

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Professional Profile

Youssef is an Environmental Consultant with 7 years of practical experience in the environmental consulting field. He has contributed to Environmental and Social Impact Assessment studies for various projects, including oil and gas, railways, industrial zones, ports and renewable energy projects. He has also conducted environmental audits, site assessments, and monitoring. Notably, he conducted environmental monitoring for the Cairo Metro Line 3 Phase 3 from 2019 to 2021 during its construction phase.

Youssef has a strong understanding of the Egyptian environmental regulations. In addition, he has worked on projects in Iraq, Ghana, Saudi Arabia, and Oman conducting studies remotely and has successfully completed projects funded by international institutions such as the IFC, World Bank, EIB, Korean Exim Bank, and the African Development Bank.

Skills

- Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA / ESIA)
- Environmental Due Diligence
- Environmental Monitoring
- Stakeholder Engagement & Public Consultation
- Environmental Auditing
- Lender-Aligned Environmental Documentation

Professional Experience

Worley

May 2023 - Nov 2025 | Cairo, Egypt

Environmental Consultant

- Contributed to ESIA's for major offshore, industrial and energy projects in Egypt and Saudi Arabia.
- Conducted environmental baseline assessments, impact evaluation, mitigation and monitoring plans.
- Performed environmental due diligence against IFC standards.
- Implemented air quality, noise and stack emission monitoring campaigns.

Selected Projects:

- Refining and Petrochemicals Complex ESIA, Ain Sokhna, Egypt (2025)
- Wind Farm EIAs, Saudi Arabia (2025)
- Project Landing, Environmental Due Diligence, UAE (2025)
- Geothermal Exploration Wells EIAs, Saudi Arabia, Ministry of Energy (2025)
- OXAGON Masterplan Scoping Reports and ESIA's, NEOM, Saudi Arabia (2024 - 2025)
- Port of NEOM Expansion ESIA, NEOM, Saudi Arabia (2024)
- Offshore Wells EIAs, Mediterranean Sea (bp, IEOC)

- Waste Management Audit, Suez Canal Container Terminal, Maersk (2025)

EcoConServ Environmental Solutions

Nov 2018 - Apr 2023 | Cairo, Egypt

Environmental Specialist

- Contributed to EIA/ESIA studies across transport, irrigation, industrial and infrastructure sectors.
- Managed technical inputs from external experts and coordinated multidisciplinary teams.
- Delivered public consultation sessions and supported stakeholder engagement activities.
- Prepared Arabic and English EIA documentation in compliance with national regulations.
- Conducted environmental audits and site assessments.
- Monitored and reported on environmental performance for Cairo Metro Line 3 Phase 3.

Notable Engagements:

- Luxor-High Dam Railway Modernization Project ESIA, Korean Exim Bank funded (2022–2023)
- Solar Electrification Projects in Ghana ESMF, African Development Bank Funded (2021)
- Emergency Operation Development Projects (Iraq), World bank Funded, Multi-sector ESMPs (2020 - 2022)
- Offshore Ethylene and VCM Receiving Terminal ESIA, Port Said (2023)
- Environmental and Social Audit, Grain Silos in Safaga, Damietta, Alexandria (2023)
- Phase I Environmental Site Assessment, Novartis Pharmaceutical Facility (2022)

Education

American University in Cairo

2018

BSc Construction Engineering

GPA: 3.98 / 4.00

International College, Beirut

2013

International Baccalaureate Diploma (42/45)

Courses

- ISO 14001:2015 - Environmental Management Systems
- Foundations of ESG and Sustainable Finance

Additional Information

Languages: Arabic (Native), English (Fluent)

Regional Experience: Egypt, Saudi Arabia, Iraq, Ghana, Oman